



Arogya Setu app mandatory

The Arogya Setu contact tracing app has been declared mandatory of all office workers. <https://digit.in/may20-17>



Byju's fundraising at \$10B valuation

Byju's, an Indian edtech startup is in talks to raise about \$400 million at a \$10 billion valuation. <https://digit.in/may20-18>

India-based SoloCoin, a social distancing gaming application has won two hackathons in rapid succession.

The app came in third at the CODE19 hackathon organised in India on April 10. The CODE19 hackathon was an effort to find technological solutions for the challenges faced by the Covid-19 outbreak and the following nationwide lockdown. On April 30, there was more good news for the app, as it went on to win first place in the "other" subcategory of the "Social & Political Cohesion" category of the pan European EUvsVirus hackathon.

The founder of the app is India-based Arbob Mehmood, a 22 year old who has previously founded Bramble. The main product of Bramble is an API that allows developers to reward gamers in cryptocurrencies for playing their games. The experience Mehmood gained from working with Bramble was used to work on SoloCoin. Specifically, a similar gamification system was used to reward people for staying at home, instead of playing the game. SoloCoin is an app that gamifies social distancing and rewards people with SoloCoins, a token currency within the application, that can be exchanged for discounts of services such as Amazon, Netflix, Swiggy, Zomato and other services

that are required for staying at home. Currently, the coupons offered on the app are sourced through third party affiliates, but the team is working on integrating these coupons natively.

Mehmood is an avid reader of our magazine, and we reached out to him to learn more about the app. One of the things that we noticed was that the app has a waitlist, and it has not been released just yet. So, we asked Mehmood why the app has a waitlist? He replied, "The app is still in development. It's in private beta right now and is only accessible via an invite-only system that too within our community. We are planning on launching this app next month globally so we want some people to try it firsthand and give feed-

back so that we can release a relatively bug-free app."

One of the effective ways in which the app, and the invite system is marketed and propagated, is through social media influencers. We asked Mehmood how the experience of working with influencers was. He responded, "I had worked with influencers in my previous startups, so, it was not new to me. We also have a community member with lots of influencer connections that helped us in connecting with them. The primary thing to know while talking with influencers is their charge because they negotiate way too much. Now, we were lucky here because we are an open-source startup tackling the COVID crisis so many of them agreed to do some of the marketing for free. Influencers can

put to gamify social-distancing and help to stop the spread of COVID resonated with people and that helped us in getting amazing people with great skills from all over the world to voluntarily work on my idea without any financial incentive. I don't think this would've have been possible if I had pitched a me-too idea or a less impactful idea in front of people. This is true for regular users and potential customers as well. There are many rewards app but the only reason we have received this much interest from the community and waitlist registration is that we were doing something that will help make the world a better place. We have learned that working towards something bigger is a much bigger reward than any discounts. With our app users had a sense of belonging and contribution towards a bigger cause. They are proud of it. And, it doesn't hurt that by doing so, they can earn rewards and recognition in their social-circle."

We then asked Mehmood to share with us, and other readers his personal journey with Digit as a reader of the magazine. Mehmood replied, "Digit has played a vital role in the development of my tech/startup mindset. I'm reading Digit since I was 13, mostly purchased from the nearest

railway station. I used to read Chacha Chaudhary and Billoo a lot during those times. But one day while I was browsing for something different I encountered Digit. The shopkeeper recommended to me that it has computers and mobile phones in it. I loved computers and working on the computer since when I was 8 but never thought to do anything with it except for getting a job.

Once I got the magazine I was hooked. I got into tech after reading amazing articles on digit. I realized how awesome career in tech can be. Not to mention the articles about tech entrepreneurs have motivated me to start my own tech startup and that led me to learn to program and founding my first startup at the age of 17." 

SoloCoin
WINS
at Code19
and EUvsVirus
hackathons

get you a great ROI if you choose them carefully according to your target market and have a way with negotiations."

One of the things that Mehmood pointed out to us, was that what really motivated people in using the app was not the money they got for discounts on products and services, but the knowledge that their efforts had in some way contributed to the global fight against the pandemic. We probed Mehmood on how he came to this realisation, and he said, "One thing I've noticed while building our product is the founder's vision and the potential impact of the said product is very important. When I first pitched the idea of SoloCoin, I was alone. But the idea was innovative and has never been done before. The vision I